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From Calabria Cometh the Law, and the Word of the Lord from Sicily: The Holy Land in the Thought of Joachim of Fiore and Abraham Abulafia

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From Calabria Cometh the Law, and the Word of the Lord from Sicily: The Holy Land in the Thought of Joachim of Fiore and Abraham Abulafia

Harvey J. Hames

An anonymous Vita written in the years immediately following Joachim of Fiore's death presents him as an alter-Jeremiah or Ezekiel, a prophet of the exile. His life is described as a transmigration from the Holy Land, where he received his first revelation, to the monastery he founded in Fiore, or as a journey from exile to redemption. Calabria becomes the new Holy Land, blessed by the Holy Spirit. In contrast, the thirteenth-century Kabbalist Abraham Abulafia depicts Sicily as the place where prophecy will be renewed and the Messiah revealed. He refers to himself as Zachariah, the prophet of redemption, particularly in work in which his connection with Christians is emphasized. This article suggests that Abulafia adapted the Joachite teachings which he would have encountered in Sicily and southern Italy to a polemical dialogue with his Christian counterparts in an attempt to prove to them that he was the one who would bring the redemption and unification of Jews and Christians in a spiritual understanding of the divine Name.

Keywords: Abraham Abulafia; Calabria; Holy Land; Joachim of Fiore; Sicily

Joachim of Fiore never claimed to be a prophet. The famous Calabrian abbot, born the son of a notary in Celico in the 1130s, who went on to found the Florentine order claimed to have been endowed with spiritual intelligence which gave him the keys to interpreting the Old and New Testaments.¹ He elaborated his conception of history as progressing towards salvation in a number of works written mainly in the last decades

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of the twelfth century. Though he was already engaged with the idea of concordance between the Old and New Testaments before the visions in Casamari in 1184, it was those visions which provided him with the mature understanding present in his central works: the *Liber de Concordia novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, the *Psalterium decem chordarum*, and the *Liber figurarum*.² Joachim developed patterns of twos and threes, the former based on the two testaments and the latter on the three persons of the Trinity as they were understood to have been revealed in history.³

Joachim's close reading of the Old Testament led him to see it as a key to understanding the events of the New Testament down to the present. His methodology was one of concordance, which he explained as being a harmony which reflected similarity between the two in character but not in dignity, meaning that the two Testaments revealed similar issues, but the New was more perfect than the Old.⁴ He envisioned the testaments as two trees, the first growing from Adam and ending with the birth of Christ and the second starting from Christ and ending with his second coming. According to Joachim's detailed calculations, each tree contained 63 generations, divided into three groups of 21, though the generations on the two trees differed in duration, the first being carnal and the second more spiritual. The Old Testament tree was divided as follows: from Adam to Isaac, from Jacob to Amasias, and from King Uziah, the king of Judah and contemporary of the prophet Isaiah, to the first coming of Christ. The New Testament tree also had three groups, two of which, implying 42 generations, were to pass before the onslaught of the Antichrist. The length of a New Testament generation was 30 years, because this represented the age of Christ when he started to have disciples (spiritual children), implying that the coming of the Antichrist would be in 1260 (42 generations of 30 years' duration each). The 12 tribes and the 12 churches (7 in Asia and the 5 metropolitan churches of Rome, Constantinople, Alexandria, Antioch and Jerusalem) were the branches of the trees.⁵ Just as Christ emerged from a branch of the tribe of Judah, so it would be from a branch of the Roman Church that the second coming would issue.

The Trinitarian pattern was probably the outcome of the second of Joachim's visions at Casamari and resulted in a significant departure from the previous understanding of the Apocalypse. St. Augustine had proposed that the 1,000-year reign of the saints with Christ was the present time of the church and all that was expected in the future was the second coming and final judgement.⁶ Joachim's understanding, however, was that the millennium was yet to come and was a third period that would be ushered in after the defeat of the first or minor Antichrist.⁷ Thus, Joachim outlined the history of the world as divided into three *statūs* (periods), each connected to one of the three persons of the Trinity and reflecting the relationships within the Trinity. Because there was progression in history towards salvation, the first *status*, that of the Father, was one in which 'men lived according to the flesh', the second, that of the Son, one 'in which men live between two poles, that is between the flesh and the spirit', and the future third *status*, that of the Holy Spirit, one 'in which people live according to the spirit'. Yet, the three *statūs* were interlinked in that the *status* of the Son, that of the current

church, had its roots in the *status* of the Father with Aaron signifying priesthood and Isaiah evangelization. The third *status* had its roots in both the first and the second, Elijah or his disciple Elisha along with St. Benedict signifying the spiritual monastic way of life that would dominate in the future.⁸

But it was the book of Revelation which provided Joachim with the framework for understanding the internal structure of each of the trees or the historical periods they represented. He understood the seven seals of Revelation 5 to represent seven periods (*tempora*) of persecution of the Jews in the Old Testament, which, using the idea of concordance, implied that there would also be seven persecutions of the church. The Jews had been persecuted by the Egyptians, the Canaanites, the Syrians, the Assyrians, the Chaldeans, the Medes, and the Greeks and the Christians by the Jews, the pagans, the Persians, Goths, Vandals, and Lombards, the Saracens, and now, in his own day, the German emperors. That left two more persecutions, with the last, represented by Antiochus in the Old Testament, being by the Antichrist. However, the last two persecutions (the sixth and seventh seals) would have to happen concurrently as the end of the second *status* was close at hand. These persecutions would be followed by the flowering of the third *status*, ushered in by two monastic orders, whereby 'there is a union of the gentile and the Hebrew people, and there will be one fold and one shepherd'.⁹ The establishment of the monastery of Fiore, high in the Sila Mountains, after Joachim had been released from his duties in the Benedictine monastery of Corazzo by Clement III in 1189, was in preparation for the events leading to the third *status*. There he sought to follow the Benedictine rule in as rigorous a fashion as possible, given that spiritual monasticism was the ultimate goal of history.¹⁰

However, although Joachim himself never claimed to be a prophet, in the *Vita* written by an anonymous Florentian disciple of his in the years immediately following his death, he is presented exactly as such.¹¹ His whole career is seen as centred on his prophetic visions, his ability to predict the future, and his being a model of the biblical prophets of the exile, Ezekiel and Jeremiah. According to the *Vita*, Joachim's first vision occurred in the Holy Land on Mt. Tabor, where he received a revelation regarding the two testaments. His perambulations in the Holy Land and the state of monastic life there convinced him that 'God in His anger and indignation had repelled this land from His sight and that its time of correction was at hand'.¹² This was a prediction that was soon to come true with the conquest of Jerusalem by Saladin in 1187. The *Vita* depicts the peak of his activity as the journey from exile to redemption — proceeding from the Holy Land to Calabria, a land blessed by the Holy Spirit, to found Fiore and initiate his monastic reforms. Just as Nazareth was the place where the second *status* was announced by the Holy Spirit, Fiore was the new Nazareth, where the annunciation of the third *status*, that of the Holy Spirit, took place. From Fiore, the Holy Spirit would go forth and the new spiritual men will evangelize the world. Thus, Joachim became a prophet in the land blessed with prophecy but shunned by God because of the state of monastic life there and emerged from exile in the new Holy Land, the land imbued with the Holy Spirit, Calabria. He predicted the fall of the former because of its sins and the restoration of the people to the latter, the new Israel.¹³

A major theme in Joachim's writings and that of his followers is the idea of the transmigration of the spiritual Jerusalem. In the concordance between the Old and New Testaments the destruction of Jerusalem by Nebuchadnezzar and the subsequent exile is paralleled by similar events towards the end of the second *status*. Yet it was not the geographical Jerusalem that interested Joachim but the spiritual one represented by the perfection of the Roman Church.¹⁴ It would seem that in the minds of his followers the establishment of Fiore in Calabria, the new Holy Land, was like the establishment of the new temple on the mountain prophesied by Ezekiel and that the transmigration of Jerusalem had taken place. Nazareth was not by the sea but in the mountains, just as Fiore was in the mountains of Calabria.¹⁵ Nazareth became Fiore, Bethlehem became Consenza, and thus, both literally and figuratively, Calabria became the new Holy Land.¹⁶

These ideas, which have strong basis in Joachim's own writings are also elaborated in the Pseudo-Joachim commentaries on Ezekiel, Jeremiah, and Isaiah, all products of the mid-to-late thirteenth century in southern Italy and Sicily. Whilst there has been disagreement about the authorship of these treatises, recent work has shown that they contain ideas which clearly originate with the Florentians themselves, although the works were then redacted by others such as the Cistercians or Franciscans, who read Francis and themselves into Joachim's vision of the two orders leading others into the third *status*.¹⁷ Thus, it is reasonable to assume that this radical reading of the significance of Fiore in particular and Calabria in general would have been well known among the followers of the teachings of Joachim. This is important because it was mainly in southern Italy and Sicily that Abraham Abulafia spread his prophecies regarding the end of the exile and messianic times.

Abulafia was born in Saragossa in 5000 AM (AD 1240), the start of the sixth millennium, a year of apocalyptic expectation in some Jewish circles.¹⁸ A trip to the Holy Land when he was 20 was curtailed in Acre by the battle of En Jalut between the Mamluks and the Mongols, which effectively ended the Mongol threat to the West. Abulafia spent time in Greece, southern Italy, and then Catalonia, where he studied and taught Maimonides' *Guide for the Perplexed* and acquired extensive knowledge of sefirotic Kabbalah and Ashkenazi pietism. Following a revelation in late 1270 and on the basis of his earlier studies, Abulafia started to develop his teachings on the basis of *Sefer Yetzirah* (Book of Creation), a mystical understanding of the *Guide*, and a unique (re)reading of the Torah. Towards the end of 1276 he received a further vision which inspired him to believe that he was the expected Messiah.¹⁹ This was the backdrop for his extensive messianic and apocalyptic activity and prophetic writings in the following years. Intensive preparation and further visions led to Abulafia's attempt to meet Pope Nicholas III, who died on the very night before Abulafia had hoped to meet with him (22 August 1280), and this messianic activity continued till late 1285, not without opposition from within the Jewish world.²⁰ Towards the end of the latter year Abulafia had another revelation which gave him perfect knowledge and caused him to see things in a different light. Although the apocalyptic elements remain in the build-up towards 1290, which he strongly believed was the year of redemption, his messianic

claims became more internalized and seem to indicate a realization that his messianic potentiality would come to fruition only at the end of time. It is perhaps no coincidence that Abulafia disappeared from the historical stage in late 1290 or early 1291, although what happened to him remains a mystery.²¹

According to rabbinic tradition, prophecy came to an end with the destruction of the temple but one of the signs of the advent of the Messiah was the renewal of prophecy. Though one was not supposed to try to calculate when this would occur, even Maimonides, citing a family tradition regarding the interpretation of one of Balaam's prophecies, suggested that prophecy would return in 4970 AM (AD 1210).²² Abulafia stated that prophecy had been renewed in the year of his birth.²³ He wrote: 'And know that most of the visions that Raziel [= 248 = Abraham] saw were constructed around the knowledge and renewal of the revelation of the ineffable Name now on the earth in his time. . . and this Name was crowned in the year 5000 [AM = AD 1240], and it is the time Abraham was born'.²⁴ In other words, his messianic pretensions were based on the assumption that prophecy had been renewed in the year of his birth and that he had the true knowledge of the Divine Name, which was the ultimate purpose of prophecy. And it was this conviction which drove him to spread his message among the Jewish communities of Greece, southern Italy, Sicily, and Catalonia.

Claims of prophetic capabilities coupled with apocalyptic messianic ideology were extremely dangerous to rabbinic authority and could not be ignored. Abulafia's claim to be a prophet was therefore a matter of serious concern for one of the foremost rabbinical figures of the time, Solomon ibn Adret. This disciple of Nahmanides and leading Halachic authority in Catalonia was approached by leaders of the community in Palermo, probably in the aftermath of the Sicilian Vespers, for advice regarding Abulafia's prophetic and messianic claims. In a rather unstable political environment, a Jew claiming to be the Messiah and a prophet and openly preaching to Jews and Christians about the impending end of Christianity might not have been exactly what the community needed, and they wanted to know whether Abulafia's claims were credible. While Solomon ibn Adret's reply has not survived, in a *responsa* dealing with the appearance of a supposed prophet in Avila he refers to Abulafia directly in language that leaves no room for doubt as to his negative opinion of the self-proclaimed prophet and Messiah.

Rabbinic tradition from the Midrash to Judah ha-Levi and Nahmanides held that prophecy was intimately connected with the Land of Israel — that it was only there that prophecy was possible. Solomon ibn Adret emphatically states that the idea that one can prophesy outside of Israel is against all accepted tradition — that Moses' prophetic activity in Egypt took place prior to the sanctification of the Land and that Ezekiel could prophesy beyond Israel's borders only because he had first prophesied in Israel.²⁵ Ibn Adret refers to Abulafia as 'that trickster, may the name of the wicked rot, Abraham, who set himself up as prophet and messiah in Sicily, who seduced with his falsehoods some of the children of Israel' and continues 'Had I not slammed the door in his face by the mercy of God, with his imaginary and false teachings, he would have started [his messianic activity] and would have

annihilated [the community]'.²⁶ Abulafia could not be a prophet because he did not meet any of the necessary criteria for the role.²⁷

Abulafia's defence of his prophetic capabilities is found in a number of places, among them *Sefer ha-Heshek*, a treatise dealing with the Divine Names and how to achieve prophecy.²⁸ Drawing on Maimonides, Abulafia writes that the essence of man is his internal being, his soul, which has the potential to receive the divine influx.²⁹ Every person has the potential, but only a few are able to attain that level. Man must first learn ordinary speech and then proceed according to his abilities with the goal of attaining the highest level of internal speech, that of Moses, with whom God spoke 'mouth to mouth'. Thus, according to Abulafia, if one has the requisite knowledge and the right temperament, one can become a prophet. As for the rabbinic tradition about the inability to prophesy outside of the Holy Land unless one had first received prophecy in the Holy Land, Abulafia suggests that it is not to be taken literally. First, he explains that Abraham received prophecy in Haran (Genesis 12:1) before arriving in the Holy Land, and if one were to say that his prophecy came before the sanctification of the Holy Land and that only subsequently the above-cited rule applied, it is important to note that first Abraham was chosen and only then the land, and therefore the individual takes precedence over the location. Yet for Abulafia the true meaning of the rabbinic saying lies in the numerical equivalence between *Ba-Aretz* (in the Land) and *Be-Homer ha-Lev* (the essence of the heart = 293) and *Nefesh* (soul) and *Hutza la-Aretz* (outside the Land = 430). For Abulafia, prophecy indeed first comes in the Land which is not the geographic Holy Land but the internal essence of the heart where the divine presence always abides, and then it can also come outside the Land, in other words, in the soul. However, this prophetic ability *in potentia* will come to fruition only in one who is deserving. Thus Abulafia completely neutralizes the importance of the geographic location of the Land of Israel, explaining that it is a reference to the descent of the divine presence on a person who is worthy of it.³⁰

Yet, it is also possible that Abulafia wanted to make sure that his prophetic credentials would stand up to scrutiny by claiming that he had indeed been in the Holy Land. In *Otzar Eden Ganuz*, a work written in late 1285, Abulafia lays out a spiritual autobiography in order to show that he has attained the highest level of knowledge. He reports that in his twentieth year 'the spirit of the Lord awoke and shook me, and I left there [Tudela] and I went directly to the Holy Land by sea and by land. And I wished to go to the Sambation River and I could not get past Acre because of the battle between Ishmael and Esau'.³¹ This trip has clear apocalyptic overtones, but Abulafia is very particular about what he mentions in this autobiographical outline and it is possible that he wished to show that he had indeed been in the Holy Land before he began to prophesy. In this context, it is also of interest that similarly to the portrayal of Joachim by the anonymous *Vita*, Abulafia goes to the Holy Land and then returns to the 'exile' in which his prophecy comes to fruition.

In his commentary on the book of Exodus, however, Abulafia takes a different tack, showing that not only is prophecy possible in Sicily but it is the place where the Messiah will be revealed. In the section of the commentary which deals with the last

three plagues and the preparations for the redemption from Egypt including the Paschal sacrifice, Abulafia writes: 'And because this book includes the Names, I will inform you [his seven students] here, that this year is the year *ha-galui* [*heh, gimel, lamed, vav, yud* = 5049] and for this reason the Torah scroll is written on parchment [*ha-gevil* = *heh, gimel, vav, yud, lamed*] so that it be a witness to the nation [*la-goyah* = *lamed, gimel, vav, yud, heh*] about the year of *ha-shmitah* [*shin, mem, tet, heh* = *shnat heh mem tet* = the year 5049],³² in which year the salvation will be revealed [*gluyah* = *gimel, lamed, vav, yud, heh*] to all'. In other words, the year 5049 AM (AD 1289) is the year when it will become apparent to all that the time of salvation is near. This is not yet the moment of redemption from exile, but it is one of the pivotal events leading up to it. Abulafia takes the letters that form the date and combines them in different sequences to form other words which equate the parchment on which the Torah is inscribed, the Divine Names which make up the Torah itself, the nation which is to be redeemed, and the year of salvation. For Abulafia, it is knowledge of the Divine Names, and particularly the Tetragrammaton, which will be the crowning moment and purpose of the redemption.

Abulafia continues: 'The secret of Sicily is *Aryeh* [Lion], [the verse] "At the mountain of the Lord He will be seen [*yeraeh*]" . . . hints at the '*iy ha-rei* [Island of Rei] because '*iy ha-rei* has *aleph yud* on either side, each hinting at half the [Hebrew] alphabet, but it has *heh resh* [the Hebrew spelling for mountain] in the middle, and their secret is down and up, up and down [*matah u-maala maala u-matah*].'³³ Sicily and *Aryeh* have the same numerical value of 219. The lion is the symbol of the tribe of Judah, representing kingship and the seed of the Messiah. The words 'At the mountain of the Lord He will be seen (*yeraeh*)' come from Genesis 22:14 and refer to the mountain where Abraham almost sacrificed Isaac, which is the locus of revelation. Changing the order of the letters in *Aryeh* produces *yeraeh* ('where the Lord is seen'), and changing it again produces *ha-rei*, which is numerically equal to 'Sicily' and is the way Abulafia refers to the island.³⁴ Thus, using the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, the Torah prefigures the Abraham who will prophesy on the island of Sicily. Abulafia's name for Sicily — *iy ha-rei* — has an *aleph* and a *yud* at the beginning and the end and a *heh* and a *resh* in the middle. *Aleph* and *yud* numerically equal 11, representing half of the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, which is the language of revelation; in addition *aleph* and *yud* can also be the abbreviation for Eretz Yisrael, the Holy Land.³⁵ The *heh* and *resh* in the middle, which spell the word for 'mountain' (*har*), as in the verse from Genesis, are numerically equal to 'down and up, up and down', implying the descent and ascent of the divine presence and intimating prophetic experience. Thus, the mountain as the locus of prophecy is surrounded by the 22 letters of the alphabet, implying the Divine Names which are revealed to the Messiah. Thus, Sicily, as its name implies, is the new Holy Land, where the Messiah will prophesy and be revealed.

Abulafia points to his connections with Christians in general and the Franciscans in particular a number of times. In one instance he says that after his attempt to see the pope he spent 28 days with the Franciscans in Rome, and elsewhere he records a dispute he had with a Christian who, not surprisingly, accepted his ideas.³⁶ His

interaction with the Franciscans can be seen from his adoption and adaptation of the Joachite ideas and concepts that they had been propagating. His extensive use of the Tetragrammaton, his calculation of 1290 as the year of the end, and his irenic vision of history following the redemption can be explained only in terms of the Franciscan Joachite context.³⁷ Abulafia of course did not accept the Christological implications of Joachimism, or acquiesce in Joachim's prophetic status. His stance was always polemical and when he used Joachite concepts it was only to enrich his Jewish worldview, which he then tried to foist on his Christian interlocutors. His portrayal of Sicily as the Holy Land must also be seen in this context, as he attempts to deny the importance of Calabria and undermine the Franciscan-Joachites' assumption of their central role as one of the two orders chosen to lead the way to the third *status*.

As part of this exercise, Abulafia also attempts to counter the portrayal of Joachim as the Old Testament prophet of exile or at least show that if Joachim represents the prophets of the exile, then he himself is the prophet of redemption. In the first two sections of *Sefer ha-Ot* (which is not one book but three separate prophetic treatises written at different junctures between 1283 and 1288), he refers to himself as Zecharyahu. Zecharyahu is the name of the biblical prophet of redemption, Zachariah, with a *vav* added at the end to make it numerically equal to Abraham (248). The first section of the treatise, written in Sicily, deals with the Tetragrammaton, the most significant and powerful Divine Name which Abulafia as the Messiah is to reveal to the world. It sets out the travails of Zecharyahu, who tries to preach but is persecuted by 12 people, ascends a mountain for 20 years, and then brings about the unification of Judaism and Christianity. Many of the motifs here are indeed reminiscent of the depiction of Joachim in the anonymous *Vita*, but what is more interesting is that in this context Abulafia specifically mentions that he was sent by God to preach to both Jews and Christians:

And he came rapidly and then was teaching and telling the word of the eternal God to the Jews, circumcised in the flesh, but not in the heart.³⁸ And the poor to whom he had been sent, and for whom he was revealed, did not take to account the manner of his coming. And they started to say things about him and his God that should not be said. And he was commanded by IEUE [the Tetragrammaton] to speak to the Christians, uncircumcised in heart and body [Ezekiel 44:7] in His name. And he did so, and he preached to them and they believed in the gospel (*besorah*) of IEUE.³⁹

In the second section of *Sefer ha-Ot*, Zecharyahu continues his preaching and is again persecuted until he is forced to take refuge on Comnino, a very small island off the coast of Malta. He refers to a small select group that follows his teachings and is critical of those who ignore the divine teachings and think themselves wise, preferring temporal wealth to spiritual gifts. Zecharyahu warns that the end of time is fast approaching and that the true resurrection will be in 1290.⁴⁰

Abulafia's use of the biblical prophet Zachariah to depict himself in his prophetic and messianic guise is surely a reflection of the polemical dialogue in which he was engaged with the Franciscans. He uses the image of the figure who prophesied redemption to counter the image of the other prophets with whom Joachim was

identified, who prophesied exile and tribulations. Abulafia is sent to preach to the poor, something which would surely resonate with the Franciscans and which refers to the spiritual knowledge that is the essence of Joachim's third *status*. He posits that the year of redemption is the year understood to be the focus of Joachite expectation following the recalculation in the aftermath of 1260. In sum, he wants to prove to his Christian interlocutors that he is the one who will bring the redemption and unification of Jews and Christians in a spiritual understanding of the Divine Name. Truly, the prophet of redemption would come forth from Sicily, bringing the divine word to Calabria and beyond.

Notes

- [1] In his bull canonizing St. Dominic, Gregory IX listed the Florentine order together with the two mendicant orders and the Cistercians as the four pillars of the church. Reeves, *Influence*, 146.
- [2] There is now consensus that the *Liber figurarum* was compiled by Joachim or one of his close disciples with later additions and changes. See Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *Figurae*, and Lerner, *Feast*, 134, 139, nn. 23, 25, 80.
- [3] On Joachim's life and thought, see among many others Reeves, *Influence*, 3–27; idem, *Joachim of Fiore*, 1–28; McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot*; Daniel, *Abbot Joachim of Fiore*, xi–xlii; Luca Potestà, *Il tempo dell'Apocalisse*.
- [4] See Daniel, *Abbot Joachim*, 62 (*Liber de concordia*, Book 2, Part 1, chap. 2).
- [5] Joachim's concordance of the 12 tribes and 12 churches is more sophisticated in that he divides them into two groups of 5 and 7 each. There were 5 tribes that received their inheritance first, and they represent the primary, outer, and active; the other 7 tribes represent the inner, spiritual and contemplative. Corresponding to this are the 5 metropolitan churches designated by Peter, which have primacy, and the 7 churches of Asia designated by John, which receive their spiritual inheritance later. Naturally, there are 5 bodily senses and 7 spiritual gifts as well. This exemplifies the Joachite conception of progression of both the individual and history from the material to the spiritual. See Reeves, 'The *Liber figurarum* of Joachim of Fiore', 78–79.
- [6] See Augustine, *City of God*, 987–91.
- [7] Joachim posits two Antichrists. The defeat of the first, the little Antichrist, represented by the seventh head of the beast of Revelation, ushers in the third *status*, pictorially represented in Joachim's figures by the open space between the seventh head of the beast and its tail which represents the second and greater Antichrist and the events leading to the end of history. See Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *Figurae*, 146–52.
- [8] Daniel, *Abbot Joachim*, 66–67.
- [9] Based on John 10:16. See *Liber de concordia*, f. 85va. On the union of gentiles and Jews, see Lerner, *Feast*, 23–37; Daniel, 'Abbot Joachim of Fiore and the Conversion of the Jews', 1–21; Sapir Abulafia, 'The Conquest of Jerusalem', 127–46. See Cohen, 'Synagoga Conversa', 332–34, questioning Joachim's originality on the issue of the Jews at the end of time.
- [10] See Lerner, *Feast*, 10; Wessley, *Joachim of Fiore*, 7.
- [11] This document was published by Barault, 'Las antiguas biografías', 207–25, and then by Grundmann, 'Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore', 437–564. A new and superior edition with an Italian translation was published by Oliverio, 'Vita beati Joachimi Abbatis'. This *Vita* is known only from a sixteenth-century manuscript made by Cornelius Pelesius, the prior of the monastery in Fiore in the late 1500s.
- [12] Oliverio, 'Vita beati Joachimi Abbatis', 221.
- [13] See Wessley, 'The Role of the Holy Land', 181–91; idem, 'The True and New Jews'.

- [14] Wessley, 'The True and New Jews', 306–7.
- [15] Pseudo-Joachim *Super Esaia* 23v.
- [16] Wessley, 'True and New Jews', 312–13, based on Rome, Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, Ms. Vatican Lat. 4959, f. 16r, 25r.
- [17] See Reeves, 'The Abbot Joachim's Disciples and the Cistercian Order', 355–71; idem, *Influence*, 149–58; Wessley, *Joachim of Fiore*, 101–35; Moynihan, 'The "Pseudo-Joachim" Commentary', 109–42.
- [18] See Yuval, 'Jewish Messianic Expectations', 105–21; idem, 'Two Nations in Your Womb', 267–305. See also Shalev-Eyni, 'Cosmological Signs in Calculating the Time of Redemption', 265–87.
- [19] Abulafia, 'Sefer ha-Yashar', 99–102. This vision has gone unnoticed by scholars and is crucial for evaluating the changes in Abulafia's self-perception at different stages of his life. It also helps to date some of his works, particularly the different parts of his prophetic book *Sefer ha-Ot*. See Hames, 'Three in One or One That is Three'.
- [20] On Abulafia's attempt to meet with the pope, see Idel, 'Abraham Abulafia and the Pope'.
- [21] There is no detailed study of Abulafia's biography, though the general outline is well known. See Jellinek, *Beth ha-Midrash*, Vol. 3, xl–xlii (citing the biographical passage from Abulafia's work *Otzar Eden Ganuz* with a few added notations); Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 119–55; idem, *Kabbalah*, 52–56; and Idel, *Messianic Mystics*, 58–100. For a fuller bibliography of Idel's writings on Abulafia, at least till 1997, see Abrams, *Bibliography*. However, see also Idel, *Absorbing Perfections*, and Wolfson, *Abraham Abulafia*.
- [22] Maimonides *Epistle to Yemen* 80–84. For the discussion of the authenticity of this passage, see Halkin's introduction, xii–xiii, and the bibliography cited there. See also Halkin and Hartman, *Epistles of Maimonides*, 145 n. 223, 169, 201–2 n. 16.
- [23] See Abulafia, 'Sefer ha-Edut', 62.
- [24] Abulafia, 'Sefer ha-Edut', 61–2, my translation. See also Abulafia's apologetic epistle *Ve-Zot li-Yehudah*, 28–29. Raziel is numerically equal to Abraham according to a hermeneutical method called Gematria which assigns a numerical value to each letter of the alphabet. Though there are different ways of calculating the value of a word using Gematria, in this case it is straightforward: The sum of the numerical values of the letters that make up the word Abraham (Aleph = 1; Bet = 2, Resh = 200, Heh = 5, Mem = 40) is equal to that of the letters that spell Raziel (Resh = 200; Zayin = 7; Yud = 10; Aleph = 1; Lamed = 30).
- [25] Maimonides *Guide for the Perplexed* 2.36, 369–73, explains that there can be no prophecy in the Diaspora because of sins and the sadness that linger while the Jews are in exile.
- [26] Solomon ibn Adret, *Responsa*, 101–2, 104, my translation. See Idel, 'The Rashba and Abraham Abulafia', 235–51.
- [27] Ibn Adret also refers to the Maimonidean tradition that a prophet has to be wise, rich, and a hero (*gibbor*). In addition, he brings examples of figures in the Jewish past who were deserving of being prophets but whose generation did not deserve them. This, naturally, applies to this generation as well. See Solomon ibn Adret, *Responsa*, 102–3.
- [28] *Sefer ha-Heshek* was definitely written after 1280 and possibly even later than 1285, for the section devoted to the discussion of prophecy outside of Israel would seem to reflect the polemic with Solomon ibn Adret. In addition, the two disciples for whom Abulafia wrote the book, Saadiah ben Isaac Galmasi and Jacob ben Abraham, are listed as his disciples in Messina in late 1285, and the former and the father of the latter are still with him in Messina in 1289. See Abulafia, *Otzar Eden Ganuz*, 369; idem, *Mafteah ha-Hochmot*, 1–2.
- [29] See Kreisel, *Prophecy*, 308–11.
- [30] Abulafia, *Sefer ha-Heshek*, 58–65, discussed in Idel, 'The Rashba and Abraham Abulafia', 238–40.
- [31] Abulafia, *Otzar Eden Ganuz*, 368, my translation.

- [32] The Shmita is the seventh year of the seven-year cycle whereby the land lies fallow and rests. Forty-nine is seven times seven cycles and the year leading to the fiftieth year, the Jubilee, and therefore of even more significance. Abulafia probably took this idea from Judah ben Barzilai of Barcelona, *Commentary to Sefer Yetzirah*, 238. See also Yuval, 'Two Nations in Your Womb', 270.
- [33] Abulafia, *Mafteah ha-Shemot*, 121, my translation.
- [34] See also Abulafia, *Sitrei Torah*, 75–76. Yeraeh = 216 = three times the 72-letter name of God. Abulafia also mentions *Aryeh* (Lion) in that context. Thus, Abulafia's name for Sicily includes within it the 72-letter name of God.
- [35] On the significance of Hebrew for Abulafia, see Idel, *Language, Torah, and Hermeneutics*, 1–28.
- [36] See, respectively, Abulafia, 'Sefer ha-Edut', 58; and idem, *Mafteah ha-Hochmot*, 89–93.
- [37] In the generation following 1260, the start of the third *status* was recalculated to 1290, as the 42 generations from Christ to the start of the third *status* should be counted from his baptism, not his birth. I will discuss these issues at length in a forthcoming book. See also Lerner, *Feast*, 23–53.
- [38] See Romans 2:28–29. Abulafia refers to the Jews' speaking as Christians from Paul onwards speak about the Jews. However, see Rabbi David Kimhi's commentary to Jeremiah 9:25.
- [39] Abulafia, 'Sefer ha-Ot', 76a, my translation. The text continues by saying that though they believed, they did not repent, as they put their trust in their 'swords and bows'.
- [40] Abulafia, 'Sefer ha-Ot', 77a–81b.

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